



TOOLBOX TALK — WEEKLY SAFETY MEETING

Millwork | Carpentry | Interior Finishes | Material Handling

WEEK 31

Date: Supervisor:

Project / Job Name:

TOPIC: Ergonomics: Kneeling, Squatting & Floor Work

OVERVIEW:

Finish carpenters spend more time at floor level than almost any other trade — installing base trim, transitions, hardwood flooring, and door hardware all require sustained kneeling and squatting. Cumulative damage to the knees, lower back, and hips from these postures is the primary source of

TALKING POINTS — Read to Crew:

1. Knee pads are the single most important ergonomic tool for floor-level work, and they must be worn, not carried. Kneeling on a hard surface — even for just a few minutes — concentrates the entire weight of the upper body on a small area of the knee joint and underlying cartilage. Over months and years, this causes bursitis, cartilage degeneration, and eventually osteoarthritis. Knee pads
2. Position variety is as important as knee pads. The same posture held for extended periods — even a comfortable one — creates localized fatigue and cumulative stress in the same joints and muscles. Alternate between kneeling on one knee, kneeling on both knees, squatting, and half-kneeling. Change position at least every 20 to 30 minutes. If a position causes pain or numbness, that is a
3. Tools and materials should come to you — not the other way around. When working at floor level, organize your work area so that frequently needed tools are within arm's reach without twisting or leaning. Repeated reaching across the body while kneeling stresses the lumbar spine in rotation, which is one of the most injury-prone movement patterns for the back. Take an extra minute at the
4. If you have persistent knee or back pain from floor-level work, report it early. Musculoskeletal injuries that are identified and treated in the early stages respond well to conservative treatment — rest, physical therapy, and workload modification. The same injuries that are ignored for months or years may require surgery and may never fully resolve. Your career depends on taking early

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS — Ask Your Crew:

- Q1: Who on this crew has knee or back issues related to floor-level work? What accommodations can we make?
- Q2: Show me how you would set up your work area for a base trim installation to reduce kneeling and reaching.

KEY SAFETY POINTS:

- Always wear knee pads when working at floor level — protect your knees
- Alternate between kneeling, half-kneeling, and squatting to reduce strain
- Use foam padding under the knees when knee pads are not sufficient
- Take a 2-minute stretch break every 30 minutes of floor-level work
- Report knee pain early — early treatment prevents chronic long-term injury

Crew sign-in sheet on page 2 — all 30 crew members sign on the following page.



CREW SIGN-IN SHEET

WEEK 31

By signing, I confirm I attended this toolbox talk and understand the topic discussed.

#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)	#	PRINT NAME	SIGNATURE (click to sign in Acrobat)
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